

experimentation," says Girish.

Even for a company accustomed to high-end manufacturing, the unpredictability proved challenging.

"It's a lot easier to do what we are doing in China. For example, if we are trying to get a mould for our bow made, it can be done in 15 days. In India, it will take two to three months," he says.

Multiple challenges

There was also the challenge of the Indian market. As they began speaking to coaches, parents and archers, Girish and Krish say they discovered a system warped by layers of intermediaries — distributors, dealers and coaches. In some cases, the same product costs several times its original value.

Eventually, in 2024, the duo released its first product, the Vishwa 37, named after Girish's son and the 37-inch distance between the two axles of the pulleys at the ends of the bow's limbs. They showcased it at tournaments and introduced it to top archers.

The response was polite but non-committal.

"People liked it. But nobody bought it," Girish says.

For serious archers, the bow was not good enough to compete with established international brands. For casual users, the bow, priced at Rs. 60,000 before dealer markup, was too expensive.

"They are already habituated to bows made by American and Chinese manufacturers. If they were to switch to our bow, it would mean adjusting once again, and, at the level they are at, they don't want to leave anything to chance," says Krish.

Just when they appeared to have reached a dead end, Girish noticed something.

"Most archers in India aren't elite seniors. They are youth and kids, and the equipment they were using wasn't made for them," he says.

Most bows imported into India are oversized and designed for taller, stronger Western users.

"The standard bows brought into India have a bow length of 37 inches. When a young archer adapts, they



Trial and error: From prototype sketches and precision machining to testing rigs and final assembly, the journey behind Imaxx Sports' indigenous compound bow was shaped through months of experimentation, redesign and engineering development. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

invariably compromise on their form. A lot of them eventually drop out of archery. That's when we realised we needed to solve a different problem. We needed to design for kids," says Krish.

They returned to the design stage and began taking their products to academies around Chennai. The feedback was immediate and unfiltered.

"Kids don't sugar-coat. If something is wrong, they tell you. Sometimes we'd get complaints like: 'It hurts to hold,' or 'It's too heavy,'" says Krish.

Each comment became a data point.

"It became a loop," he says. "Test, change, test again."

Breakthrough product

The result of this process was the Tej 28 series, bows designed specifically for younger archers, with a shorter draw length of 28 inches and a draw weight between 15 and 40 pounds.

Built with frames made from aviation-grade 6061 aluminium and fibreglass limbs, the bows were lighter, more ergonomic and tailored to Indian body types. With a dealer price of less than Rs. 20,000, they were also far cheaper than comparable products built overseas.

For the first time, Girish felt they had something that genuinely addressed a gap.

The response was encouraging. Their initial small batches sold out quickly. Enquiries have started coming in from academies across the country.

The path ahead, however, is not entirely clear.

Girish admits challenges remain for Imaxx Sports. Pricing, he says, continues to be a sticking point. International prices of the alloy used for the riser (the section to which the limbs connect), have risen by a third over the last couple of months because of the war in Iran. Meanwhile, cheap imports continue to flood the market.

At one point, Girish even considered selling at minimal margins simply to gain traction.

For now, Girish remains optimistic. The company has introduced more cost-effective bows with a 10m range for archers under six years old and is bringing out a larger bow, the Tej 34, for archers between 13 and 16 years old.

As an Indian manufacturer, they also offer servicing and repairs — something far harder to obtain with imported bows and considered a major headache by users.

Already, five archers competed with the Tej 28 at the most recent U-13 Nationals in Guntur and, with the first medals won there, Girish believes he finally has a product capable of competing with the best.